EcoTipping Points Facilitation Guides

Constraints Worksheet

Reality-check your approach before committing to it.

The best intervention is one your community group can actually carry out. This worksheet helps you test a proposed approach against real conditions, not ideal ones, so you can design something that fits.

Use this after you've identified a potential intervention (Reverse It) and before you commit time and resources.

Name your proposed approach

What are you planning to do? Describe it in one or two sentences.

What does this approach need to work?

For each category, write down what your approach requires and what's actually available. Be specific and honest. A gap here is information you need to design well, not a reason to quit.

People and labor

What the approach needs	What's actually available	What to do?
How many people? What skills? How much of their time? When?	Who's willing and able? What competing demands on their time exist (farming seasons, wage labor, caregiving)?	Can you close the gap? Will you adjust the approach? Or is this a dealbreaker?

Money and materials

What the approach needs	What's actually available	What to do?
What needs to be purchased? What are the ongoing costs, not just startup? What materials or equipment?	What financial resources do you have or can you access? What can be sourced locally without cash? Are community members willing to help those making the greatest personal sacrifices to income? What happens if funding is delayed or cut?	Can you close the gap? Will you adjust the approach? Or is this a dealbreaker?

Knowledge and skills

What the approach needs	What's actually available	What to do?
What technical knowledge is required? What facilitation or organizational skills?	What expertise exists in the community already? Do we have leadership that will maintain and enforce? What needs to come from outside? Is that outside expertise reliably available? See also: Enduring Commitment of Local Leadership, Social and Ecological Memory.	Can you close the gap? Will you adjust the approach? Or is this a dealbreaker?

Time

What the approach needs	What's actually available	What to do?
How long before you see results? What seasonal windows and harvest schedules matter? What's the minimum commitment before you can evaluate whether it's working?	How urgent is the problem? How long can the community sustain effort before needing visible results? Are there hard deadlines (donor timelines, weather patterns, ecological recovery windows)?	Can you close the gap? Will you adjust the approach? Or is this a dealbreaker?

Who might resist, and what can they do about it?

Identify specific people, groups, or institutions that might oppose the approach and what power they actually hold.

Who might resist?	Why?	What power do they have to block or undermine this?

In Gopalpura, the government tried to shut down johad construction. In Punukula, pesticide dealers threatened debt collection. Knowing who might push back — and how — lets you plan for it rather than be surprised by it.

For strategies on navigating resistance, consider whether avenues exist to counter or work around it. See also: Overcoming Social Obstacles (Ingredient for Success).

What are you depending on that you don't control?

List anything external your approach requires but that you can't guarantee: government permits, donor approval, market access, cooperation from neighboring communities, weather patterns, supply chains.

For each one: what happens to your plan if this doesn't come through?

External dependency	What happens without it?

The risk question

What happens to the community if this approach fails or takes much longer than expected?

Can families absorb the cost of failure, or would it make things worse?

Is there a way to start small enough that failure is survivable?

What's the minimum viable version of this approach: the smallest thing you could try that would still tell you whether it's working?

Khao Din farmers couldn't afford to abandon cash crops overnight. A bad harvest could mean starvation. They converted gradually, field by field, learning as they went. Whether your approach is right matters less than whether the path to it fits what people can actually risk.

Redesign check

Look at what you've written. Where are the biggest gaps between what your approach needs and what's available?

For each major gap, choose one:

☐ We can close this gap. How? Write it down. This becomes part of your plan.

☐ We need to modify the approach to work within this constraint. What changes?

☐ This is a dealbreaker. We need a different approach.

If you're modifying, write your revised approach here:

Before you move on

Your approach should now reflect what your community group can actually do, not what would work in ideal conditions. A smaller intervention that fits real constraints will outperform an ambitious one that falls apart.

Three signs your approach is well-matched to your situation:

The resources it needs are things the community already has or can realistically get.

You can describe the first concrete step, and people know who's doing it.

If it goes wrong, the community isn't worse off than before.